DIGITALAIKART · DIGITAL EDITION

The AI Certification Reality Check

2026-27

Which AI certificates are actually worth your money in India — verified fees, honest verdicts, and the ₹0 route that beats most of them

8
paid credentials, fees verified

3
30-day plans, one per reader

₹3,691
the cheapest real credential in India

Every fee, format, validity period and retirement date checked against the vendor's own page on 28 October 2026

Digitalaikart · digitalkartai.shop

Read This First

This book answers one question that nobody selling AI courses wants to answer plainly: **is this certificate worth the money to me, specifically, in India, right now?**

Every fee, exam duration, question count, validity period and retirement date in these pages was checked against the vendor's own official page on **28 October 2026**. Where a vendor publishes a rupee price for India, that rupee price is used. Where it does not, the US dollar fee is given and a rupee estimate is shown at ₹95 to the dollar, the market rate on 27 October 2026. Nothing here is copied from a course seller's blog, because those pages are almost always out of date and always motivated.

What this book will not do is tell you that a certificate will change your life. The research is clearer than the marketing, and the research says something more useful: **AI skills raise your interview chances a lot; the certificate itself adds only a little on top.** That single finding should reorder how you spend your money. Most of this book is about spending it in the right order.

> **How to use it in ten minutes**
> If you are in a hurry, read The Five-Minute Answer, then jump to the verdict for the one credential you were considering. If you have an hour, read Part 1 first — it will probably save you more money than any discount you will find.

What is verified, and what is an estimate

- **Verified** — exam fees, durations, question counts, validity periods, retake rules, domain weightings, retirement dates. Taken from the official exam pages listed in the Appendix.
- **Estimate** — rupee conversions of dollar fees, using ₹95 = $1. Marked as approximate everywhere they appear.
- **Judgement** — the verdicts. They are mine, built on the fee data and on the hiring research in Part 1. Where I say skip, I say why, and you can disagree with a reason.

How this book is organised

Part	The question it answers
1	What the research and the Indian hiring data actually say about whether certificates matter
2	Every fee, format and validity period, verified, on one page
3	Eight verdicts, one per credential, plus the scorecard that scores all eight
4	What each credential costs to hold over six years, not just to earn once
5	The ₹0 route, and what free credentials genuinely give you
6	The five traps that waste the most money in this market
7	What to build instead, in thirty days, for nothing
8	Three 30-day study plans, one per kind of reader
9	Four budgets, and the eight-point check before you pay
10	Templates: the reimbursement email, resume lines, the ninety-second interview answer

Part	The question it answers
11	Eight practice questions in the style of the real exams, with explanations
12	Exam day, without the administrative disasters
13	The questions people actually ask

Fees change. Vendors reprice at least once a year, and exchange-rate adjustments are announced with as little as 30 days' notice — AWS says so explicitly on its pricing page. Before you pay anything, re-run the six-point check in the Appendix. It takes four minutes.

The Five-Minute Answer

Find your situation. Do what it says. The reasoning is in the parts that follow.

Your situation	Do this	Cost
Non-technical professional (sales, HR, ops, marketing, founder) who needs to talk credibly about AI	Google Cloud Generative AI Leader — or nothing at all, if you only need the vocabulary. It is business-level and has no prerequisites.	$99 ~ ₹9,400
Fresher or final-year student, no cloud background, wants a first AI credential on the CV	Microsoft Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901). Cheapest real credential, never expires, and India is one of the cheapest countries to sit it.	₹3,691
Working professional already on AWS	AWS Certified AI Practitioner. Three-year validity and it auto-recognises if you later earn the ML Engineer Associate.	$100 (₹8,553 in INR)
Data or platform engineer who already builds with Databricks	Databricks Certified Generative AI Engineer Associate. The most job-specific exam on this list.	$200
Developer with 2+ years of production experience, wants the credential that carries the most weight	AWS Certified Generative AI Developer – Professional (AIP-C01). Expensive, and the only one here that is unambiguously senior-level.	$300
Anyone who has not yet built one working AI project	Nothing on this list. Spend 30 days on Part 7 first, then come back. A certificate with no project behind it is the weakest signal you can buy.	₹0
Budget under ₹5,000 and a genuine interest	The ₹0 route in Part 5, then AI-901. You will end up better off than someone who paid ₹40,000 for a course bundle.	₹0 to ₹3,691

The one-line rule

Buy the cheapest credential that matches the job you are actually applying for, and buy it only after you have one project to show. In every other case, the money is better spent on a domain name and a cloud bill.

Part 1 — What the Evidence Actually Says

Before the fees, the finding that should decide your budget. In 2026 a team of researchers ran a controlled experiment with **1,725 recruiters** in the United Kingdom, the United States and Germany. Each recruiter saw pairs of otherwise identical CVs and picked who to interview. The only thing that changed between CVs was how AI skill was presented: not at all, self-declared, or backed by a LinkedIn, company or university certificate.

The results, published as a working paper this year, are unusually clean:

- **Mentioning AI skills at all raised interview invitations by roughly 8 to 15 percentage points** across the three occupations tested (software engineer, office assistant, graphic designer).
- **Formal certificates added only a modest amount on top of self-declaration.** University and company certificates produced the highest predicted probabilities, but the confidence intervals overlapped with plain self-reported skills. In the researchers' words, the primary effect is binary: having any AI skill matters more than the specific source of that skill.
- **One group did gain decisively from a certificate** — office assistants without tertiary education, where a university-issued AI certificate lifted interview probability by up to 25 percentage points. When the conventional credential is missing, the AI certificate compensates for it.
- **Creative roles were different.** Recruiters hiring graphic designers were markedly more sceptical: 43.8% of their open-text comments about AI skills were negative. In design, an AI certificate is not the asset it is in engineering.

Read that again, because it is the whole argument of this book in one line: **the certificate is not the signal. The skill is the signal, and the certificate is a cheap way of making the skill legible.** That is still worth paying for — but it sets a hard ceiling on what any certificate is worth. It is a ₹4,000–₹10,000 decision, not a ₹50,000 one.

The employers' side, in 2026

Employer surveys point the same way, with one uncomfortable detail. The 2026 WGU Workforce Decoded report, based on 3,128 US employers, found that **91% now view non-degree certificates as at least somewhat valuable** for demonstrating skills — up from 86% a year earlier. But the same survey found **60% of employers say AI is making it harder to tell whether a candidate's skills are real**, and the share still figuring out how to assess AI skills doubled in a year, from 16% to 32%.

That is the gap you are buying into. Certificates are valued more than ever, at exactly the moment employers trust them less as proof of anything. Which is why the vendor name on the certificate matters so much: a proctored exam from Microsoft, AWS, Google, NVIDIA or Databricks is checkable in a way that a completion certificate from an online course is not. The Pearson VUE 2026 Value of IT Certification employer report describes certification as a filter and a "trusted verification marker" — organisations use it to reduce the risk that someone exaggerated a CV.

How hiring managers actually want AI skills shown

A Resume Genius survey reported in 2026 asked hiring managers how they prefer candidates to demonstrate AI skills. The ranking was blunt:

Preferred way to show AI skill	Share of hiring managers
Describing AI's impact on their work, or a task completed in the interview	26%
Mentioning it briefly on the resume	19%
Showing it through work examples	19%
Certifications or courses	15%
Would rather candidates did not emphasise AI skills at all	21%

Two conclusions. First, **certifications rank fourth** — real, but behind three things that cost nothing. Second, **one in five hiring managers actively dislikes AI emphasis**. If you stack four AI badges in your headline, you are optimising for the 15% and annoying the 21%.

So what is a certificate actually for?

It does four things that nothing else does as cheaply:

- **It forces coverage.** An exam blueprint tells you exactly what you do not know. Self-study without a syllabus drifts towards whatever is interesting.
- **It survives a keyword filter.** Some job postings and some recruiters' screening tools look for named credentials. A free badge will not match a posting that names AI-901.
- **It is checkable.** Anyone can verify a proctored credential. In a market where 60% of employers suspect CV inflation, checkability has a price.
- **It has a deadline.** A booked exam date is the most reliable study motivator ever invented, and it costs less than any course that promises accountability.

And it does not do the thing people hope it does: it does not substitute for a project. Every credential on this list tests knowledge. None of them tests whether you have shipped anything. If you have shipped nothing, fix that first — Part 7 shows you how in three weeks.

The India demand picture, in numbers

Everything above is global research. The Indian data points the same way, and it is worth knowing which way the demand is actually running, because it should decide which vendor you learn first.

Naukri's World AI Day Report 2026, built on more than 3 lakh job descriptions, nearly 27,000 professionals and recruiter search data, found that **AI skills now appear in 15.4% of technology job descriptions** — up from 0.9% in 2020, a roughly 17-fold increase. In non-technology roles the share is smaller but growing faster in relative terms: 0.26% in 2020 to 1.59% in 2026, nearly six times over.

The most useful part of that report for a buyer is the change in what recruiters search for, because a search is demand expressed before a posting is written:

Recruiter search term on Naukri	Year-on-year change
Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)	4.8x
Azure AI	2.9x
Large Language Models (LLMs)	2.4x
AI Solutions	2.1x

Recruiter search term on Naukri	Year-on-year change
Prompt Engineering	1.6x

Two conclusions, and they are the ones this book's verdicts are built on. First, **Azure AI is the second-fastest-growing search term in the country** — which is why the cheapest exam on this list is also one of the most relevant, and not merely the cheapest. Second, **RAG at 4.8x is the single biggest jump**, which is precisely the skill the Databricks and AWS Professional exams test and precisely what a portfolio project should demonstrate.

The monthly hiring indices tell the same story with more noise. Naukri's JobSpeak data showed AI/ML roles growing 25% year on year in June 2026, and 37% in March 2026, while overall IT hiring fell 3% in June — AI hiring inside IT grew 16% even as the sector shrank. AI/ML roles finished FY26 up 45%. Treat any single month with suspicion; the direction across two years is unambiguous.

One more number matters to anyone deciding whether to pay for a course. The same Naukri report found **77% of professionals use AI at work, but only 35% receive structured AI training from their employer**, and 23% are self-learning. You are not behind because you have not been trained. You are in the majority — which is exactly why a checkable credential plus one project still separates people.

The signal ladder

From strongest to weakest, as employers read it: (1) you built something that works and can explain the trade-offs; (2) you can describe a measured result; (3) you hold a proctored, vendor-issued certificate; (4) you completed an online course with a certificate of completion; (5) you list AI in your skills section. Most people buy level 3 hoping it reads like level 1. It never does. Buy level 3 after you have level 1.

Part 2 — The Verified Fee Table

Eight paid credentials, every figure from the vendor's own page, checked 28 October 2026. Rupee figures marked ~ are conversions at ₹95 = $1 and will move with the exchange rate; where a vendor publishes an India price, that figure is given instead and marked as such.

Credential (exam code)	Level	Fee	India price	Time / Qs	Valid
Microsoft Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901)	Fundamentals	$99	₹3,691 (published)	45 min	Never
Google Cloud Generative AI Leader	Foundational	$99	~ ₹9,400	90 min / 50–60	3 years
AWS Certified AI Practitioner (AIF-C01)	Foundational	$100	₹8,553 (published)	90 min / 65	3 years
NVIDIA Generative AI LLMs (NCA-GENL)	Associate	$125	~ ₹11,900	60 min / 50–60	2 years
Databricks Generative AI Engineer Associate	Associate	$200	~ ₹19,000	90 min / 45	2 years
Google Cloud Professional ML Engineer	Professional	$200	~ ₹19,000	120 min / 50–60	2 years
Google Cloud Professional Agentic Architect	Professional	$200	~ ₹19,000	120 min + labs	1 year
AWS Generative AI Developer – Professional (AIP-C01)	Professional	$300	~ ₹28,500	180 min / 75	3 years

Four things in that table that change the decision

1. The cheapest exam is not the cheapest in dollars. Microsoft's India price for a Fundamentals exam is ₹3,691 — far below the ₹9,405 that $99 converts to. Microsoft prices per country, and India is one of its cheaper markets. The same exam costs £64 in the UK and ¥12,180 in Japan. If a dollar figure is your only reference point, you will overestimate the cost of the Microsoft route by more than half.

2. AWS prices in rupees too, and the rupee price is better than the card conversion. AWS publishes ₹8,553 for its Foundational tier on the Pearson Mindhub voucher store, against roughly ₹9,500 if you pay $100 by card at today's rate. AWS's own pricing page notes that rupee pricing is accepted on the Mindhub voucher store only. Compare both routes at checkout — the difference is a few hundred rupees, but it is free money.

3. Validity is not a detail, it is half the cost. A $200 exam you must retake every two years costs $100 a year to hold. A $99 exam that never expires costs nothing to hold. Part 4 does the six-year arithmetic; it is the single most overlooked number in certification planning.

4. Taxes and payment method. Every vendor states that prices exclude applicable taxes, and Indian exam bookings attract tax on top. Budget 15–20% above the list fee unless the checkout shows you a final rupee amount you are happy with. Also check which card you use: an Indian card paying a dollar charge adds a currency-markup fee, which is exactly why the published rupee routes exist.

Free retakes almost never exist

Microsoft: retakes are charged, with a 24-hour wait after a first failure and 14 days between later attempts, capped at five attempts in 12 months. AWS: 14-day wait, no attempt cap, full fee each time. NVIDIA: 14-day wait, maximum five attempts in 12 months, and you buy the exam again. Databricks: no free retakes at all, 14 days between attempts. Plan for one attempt. Budget for two.

Part 3 — The Verdicts

Eight credentials, judged on the only four things that matter to an Indian buyer: what the exam actually tests, who it opens doors for, what it costs to hold over six years, and whether a hiring manager would care. Each verdict is graded:

- **BUY** — worth the fee for the right person, on its own merits.
- **BUY IF** — genuinely useful, but only in a specific situation.
- **SKIP** — not because the exam is bad, but because the money buys more somewhere else.

3.1 Microsoft Azure AI Fundamentals — AI-901

BUY — THE BEST VALUE FIRST CREDENTIAL IN INDIA

At a glance	
Fee	$99 in the US; ₹3,691 published India price; taxes extra
Format	45 minutes, proctored online or at a Pearson VUE centre; 13 languages
Pass mark	700 (scaled)
Blueprint	AI concepts and capabilities 40–45%; implementing AI solutions with Microsoft Foundry 55–60%
Prerequisites	None formal, but Microsoft now expects basic Python syntax and familiarity with Azure resources
Validity	Never expires. Fundamentals certifications carry no renewal requirement.
Retakes	Charged. 24-hour wait, then 14 days between attempts, maximum five in 12 months

What it actually tests

This is not a certificate that proves you can build AI. It proves you understand the shape of the field and can drive Azure's tooling: what a workload is, how machine learning differs from generative AI, what computer vision and natural-language workloads look like, and — the majority of the marks — how to put a simple AI solution together in Microsoft Foundry. Expect questions on model choice, prompt basics, evaluation and responsible-AI principles.

The exam changed materially on 15 April 2026. Its predecessor, AI-900, was retired on 30 June 2026, and the replacement is not a rename: the blueprint shifted from describing concepts to implementing them, and basic Python is now assumed. Anyone preparing from a 2025 video course is preparing for a different exam. Check the date on any material you buy.

Who should take it

- **Freshers and final-year students.** At ₹3,691 this is the cheapest proctored, vendor-issued AI credential available in India, and it never expires. As a line on a first CV, it is the highest value-per-rupee on this list.
- **Career switchers from non-technical roles.** The research in Part 1 found that AI credentials compensate most for candidates without a strong conventional education signal. A never-expiring Microsoft credential is the cleanest version of that compensation.
- **Anyone whose employer runs Microsoft 365 or Azure.** It is the credential their IT and HR teams recognise without explanation.

Who should skip it

Anyone with two or more years of hands-on ML or cloud engineering experience. AI-901 will not tell an interviewer anything they cannot see from your work, and the 45 minutes plus prep time is better spent on AI-102 or on a cloud-native exam at Associate level. Also skip it if your target employer is explicitly an AWS or Google shop and you have no interest in Azure — the concepts transfer, the vocabulary does not.

Realistic prep

Two to three weeks at roughly an hour a day for a technical beginner, using the free Microsoft Learn path and the official practice assessment, both of which cost nothing. There is no student discount in India — Microsoft's academic pricing is available in most countries but not in India or China, a fact worth knowing before you follow advice written for US students. The only listed offer is Exam Replay, bought through Pearson VUE, which bundles one exam with one retake inside 12 months. **Six-year cost of ownership: $99 once.** No renewal, no fee, no expiry. Nothing else on this list comes close on that measure.

3.2 Google Cloud Generative AI Leader

BUY — THE BEST CREDENTIAL FOR NON-TECHNICAL PROFESSIONALS

At a glance	
Fee	$99 plus tax; no separate India price published — budget ~ ₹9,400
Format	90 minutes, 50–60 multiple-choice questions, online-proctored or at a test centre
Blueprint	Fundamentals of gen AI ~30%; Google Cloud's gen AI offerings ~35%; techniques to improve model output ~20%; business strategy for a successful gen AI solution ~15%
Prerequisites	None. Google states it is for any job role, with or without hands-on technical experience.
Validity	3 years
Languages	English, Japanese, Spanish, Portuguese

What it actually tests

Business judgement about generative AI, in Google's vocabulary. Two-thirds of the marks sit in the first two domains: knowing what generative AI can and cannot do, and knowing which Google Cloud product does which job. The last third asks how you would improve model output and how you would justify an AI programme to a business. There is no coding, and no expectation that you can build anything.

Who should take it

- **Managers, sales and marketing leads, HR, operations and founders** who are being asked to "do something with AI" and need to hold their own in a vendor meeting without bluffing.
- **Consultants and pre-sales staff**, for whom a recognised cloud credential is a procurement checkbox as much as a skill signal.
- **Anyone in a Google Workspace organisation** — the vocabulary maps directly onto tools they already use.

Who should skip it

Engineers. It will not test anything you do, and an engineering manager will read it as a business credential, which is fine but not what you need. Also skip it if you are choosing between this and AI-901 on a tight budget with no employer preference: AI-901 costs ₹3,691 in India, never expires, and carries more technical weight.

Realistic prep

One to two weeks. Google publishes a learning path on Google Skills (formerly Google Cloud Skills Boost), and many of its courses and skill badges are free. The exam is 90 minutes for 50–60 questions — comfortable, provided you have actually read the domain weightings rather than skimmed a summary video. **Six-year cost of ownership: $198** — the exam twice, because a three-year credential needs one renewal inside six years.

3.3 AWS Certified AI Practitioner — AIF-C01

BUY IF — YOU WORK IN AN AWS SHOP

At a glance	
Fee	$100; AWS publishes ₹8,553 for its Foundational tier on the Pearson Mindhub voucher store
Format	90 minutes, 65 questions, Pearson VUE centre or online-proctored, 12 languages
Level	Foundational — the entry tier of AWS certification
Validity	3 years
Recertification	Pass the latest version of the exam, or earn the AWS Certified Machine Learning Engineer – Associate, which recertifies this one automatically

What it actually tests

AWS-shaped AI literacy: which service does what, what a foundation model is in Bedrock, how responsible AI and security fit, and how to judge whether a use case is worth doing at all. AWS describes the intended candidate as anyone exploring AI/ML on AWS — cloud, development, data, IT or line-of-business roles. It is broad rather than deep, which is exactly what a foundational exam should be.

Who should take it

People whose employer or target employer already runs on AWS, where a named AWS credential clears an internal or client filter that no other certificate will. It is also the sensible first step if you intend to continue to the ML Engineer – Associate, because of the automatic recertification path — that is a genuinely useful piece of design and it saves you a renewal fee later.

Who should skip it

If you have no AWS exposure and no employer preference, the AWS route is the most expensive of the three foundational options in rupee terms (₹8,553 against ₹3,691) for a credential of similar weight. Learn AI on the cheapest credible platform, then specialise when a job tells you which cloud it uses.

Realistic prep

Two to four weeks, using the 900+ free self-paced courses on AWS Skill Builder. The exam is longer than AI-901 — 90 minutes, 65 questions. **Six-year cost of ownership: $200** — two attempts, since the credential expires at three years.

3.4 Databricks Certified Generative AI Engineer Associate

BUY IF — YOU ALREADY BUILD ON DATABRICKS

At a glance	
Fee	$200 plus applicable taxes; ~ ₹19,000. All Databricks exams cost $200.
Format	90 minutes, 45 scored multiple-choice and multiple-selection questions, online-proctored, no test aids
Blueprint	Design applications 14%; data preparation 14%; application development 30%; assembling and deploying 22%; governance 8%; evaluation and monitoring 12%
Recommended experience	Six months of hands-on Databricks platform experience
Validity	2 years. Recertify by taking the full current exam again.
Retakes	Full fee, no free retakes, 14-day wait between attempts, no attempt cap

What it actually tests

This is the most specific exam on the list, and that is its strength. It tests whether you can build a retrieval-augmented generation application and an LLM chain on Databricks specifically: AI Search for semantic retrieval, Model Serving for deployment, MLflow for lifecycle, Unity Catalog for governance, and evaluation and monitoring for the part everyone skips. Thirty per cent of the marks are in application development. There is no way to pass it by memorising definitions.

Who should take it

Data engineers, ML engineers and analytics engineers who already work in Databricks, or who are applying to companies that do. In a Databricks shop, this credential is worth more than any of the general cloud AI exams because it maps one-to-one onto the work. It is also the best answer to the "prove you can build" problem, short of shipping a product.

Who should skip it

Anyone without platform access. Six months of hands-on experience is the recommended baseline, and the exam is priced accordingly at $200 with no free retake — an expensive way to discover you have only read about Unity Catalog. If your employer does not use Databricks, use Databricks Free Edition to build one project first, then decide.

Realistic prep

Four to eight weeks. Databricks publishes the exam guide free, offers a free edition of the platform, and its on-demand Academy courses are free. There is no official practice exam, which raises the risk on a $200 attempt — so build something end-to-end before you book. **Six-year cost of ownership: $600** — three attempts across six years at a two-year validity. This is the second most expensive credential to hold on this list, and almost nobody factors it in.

3.5 Google Cloud Professional Machine Learning Engineer

BUY IF — YOU ARE A WORKING ML ENGINEER ON GOOGLE CLOUD

At a glance	
Fee	$200 plus tax; ~ ₹19,000
Format	2 hours, 50–60 multiple-choice and multiple-select questions, online or on-site proctored
Recommended experience	3+ years in industry, including 1+ year designing and managing solutions on Google Cloud
Validity	2 years. Recertification means retaking the exam within the eligibility window, which opens 60 days before expiry.
Note	Google states the exam does not cover generative AI, because the tools for building gen-AI solutions evolve too quickly

What it actually tests

Classical and production ML engineering on Google Cloud: model architecture, data and ML pipelines, MLOps, metrics interpretation, responsible AI, plus the surrounding data engineering, infrastructure and governance. Google is explicit that generative AI is out of scope — this is the serious, unglamorous exam about making models work reliably at scale. That exclusion is a feature: it is one of the few AI-adjacent credentials whose content will not be obsolete in eighteen months.

Who should take it

Engineers with real production experience, especially in consulting, services or enterprise environments where a Professional-level cloud credential is a contract or procurement requirement. It is also the credential that most reliably survives a recruiter's filter for "ML engineer, GCP" roles.

Who should skip it

Anyone who cannot honestly claim three years of industry experience. The exam assumes you have operated models, not trained one in a notebook. Freshers should not attempt it, and people who want a generative-AI credential should look at Google's Generative AI Leader or the new Agentic Architect instead — this exam deliberately does not cover that ground.

Realistic prep

Six to ten weeks for a working engineer. Google's Professional exams are known for scenario questions rather than recall, so hands-on time matters more than reading. Budget a little for cloud usage in your own project. **Six-year cost of ownership: $600.**

3.6 AWS Certified Generative AI Developer – Professional (AIP-C01)

BUY IF — YOU ARE A SENIOR DEVELOPER AND THE EMPLOYER ASKED FOR IT

At a glance	
Fee	$300; ~ ₹28,500 — AWS's standard Professional-tier price
Format	180 minutes, 75 questions, multiple choice or multiple response, Pearson VUE or online-proctored
Languages	English, Japanese, Korean, Simplified Chinese
Target candidate	2+ years building production applications on AWS, with about a year of implementing generative-AI solutions
Validity	3 years
History	Launched in beta at roughly $150; the beta window closed 31 March 2026, so the discount is gone

What it actually tests

Whether you can take generative AI past the prototype: designing and implementing AI solutions on Bedrock, prompt engineering and prompt management at scale, agentic implementations, troubleshooting, monitoring and optimising for cost and performance, responsible-AI practice, and integrating AI into business workflows. It is a build-and-operate exam, not a concepts exam.

Who should take it

Senior developers and architects whose work already involves Bedrock and production AI systems, particularly in organisations that sell into AWS-partner ecosystems, where the credential has commercial value beyond the CV. It is also the strongest technical signal on this list for a hiring manager who already trusts AWS certifications.

Who should skip it

Almost everyone else. At $300 with no free retake and a 180-minute exam, this is not a learning tool. If you are choosing your first AI credential, this is the wrong end of the ladder — start with AI Practitioner and come back in two years. Also note the 75-question, three-hour format: the fatigue itself is a risk factor.

Realistic prep

Eight to twelve weeks for an experienced AWS developer, with real Bedrock usage. AWS Skill Builder has exam-prep content and an official practice exam; expect to spend a little on cloud usage for labs. **Six-year cost of ownership: $600** — two attempts across six years at three-year validity.

3.7 NVIDIA-Certified Associate: Generative AI LLMs (NCA-GENL)

SKIP — FOR MOST INDIANS, THE MONEY BUYS MORE ELSEWHERE

At a glance	
Fee	$125; ~ ₹11,900, taxes may apply in some countries
Format	1 hour, 50–60 multiple choice, online with remote proctoring through Certiverse. No test-centre option.
Prerequisites	None required; NVIDIA lists a basic understanding of generative AI and LLMs
Validity	2 years; recertification means retaking the exam
Retakes	You buy the exam again. 14-day wait after a failure, maximum five attempts in 12 months
Scoring	Pass/fail only — NVIDIA does not publish a cut score or report a numeric score

Why the verdict is skip, not bad

The exam is legitimate and NVIDIA's name carries real weight in AI infrastructure. The problem is fit and arithmetic. At $125 for a two-year credential you are paying roughly $62.50 a year to hold it — nearly double the annualised cost of the AWS or Google foundational exams — and unlike those, it is tied to one vendor's stack in a way that most Indian job postings do not reference. NVIDIA's own recommended training runs $30–$90 per self-paced course, and its instructor-led workshops are around $500 each, so the total cost of a prepared attempt is rarely $125.

There is also a scoring transparency issue: with no published cut score and no numeric result, you cannot tell how close you were, which makes a second paid attempt a guess rather than a plan.

Take it only if

Your job is genuinely in AI infrastructure or GPU-accelerated computing, your employer will reimburse the fee, or you are targeting an organisation that explicitly lists NVIDIA certification. In those cases it is a sensible, focused credential. Outside them, the same ₹12,000 buys AI-901 plus a Databricks Free Edition project and a domain name. **Six-year cost of ownership: $375** — three attempts at two-year validity.

3.8 Google Cloud Professional Agentic Architect

WAIT — REAL CREDENTIAL, UNFINISHED LOGISTICS

At a glance	
Fee	$200 retail plus tax; ~ ₹19,000. The beta ran at $120 and closed 30 September 2026.
Status	Beta closed. Google says general-availability registration opens 2 November 2026, with the exam expected mid-November.
Format	Two parts, both required: a 2-hour proctored multiple-choice exam delivered by Pearson, then hands-on labs in Google Skills, to be completed within two months of passing part one
Blueprint	Low-code agent building ~13%; coding agents ~17%; developing custom agents ~33%; evaluating and deploying agentic workflows ~22%; securing and governing them ~15%
Recommended experience	3+ years building cloud solutions, including 1+ year building agentic solutions on Google Cloud
Validity	1 year — the shortest on this list

The honest position

This is the most interesting new AI credential of 2026 and the one most likely to be worth something in 2027, because agentic systems are where the hiring is moving. It is also the only exam here that requires you to pass hands-on labs as well as a written paper, which makes it a far better signal of ability than any multiple-choice test — and it is graded against a one-year validity, the shortest on the list.

The reason to wait is not the quality of the exam. It is that general availability has not opened yet at the time of writing, so there is no settled GA question count, no confirmed language list, and no track record of what the labs demand. Paying $200 into an exam whose GA logistics are still being published is a bet on the vendor's calendar, not on your skills.

What to do instead, right now

Prepare as though you will sit it in Q1 2027. Build two agentic workflows on Google Cloud, document the failure modes, and read the published exam guide's five domains. Then book when GA pricing and format are confirmed on the official certification page — and re-check the validity period before you pay, because a one-year credential at $200 is $200 a year to hold, which is the worst holding cost on this list. **Six-year cost of ownership: $1,200** if you maintain it continuously — six renewals. Almost nobody should.

3.9 The scorecard — all eight, scored

Verdicts in prose are easy to argue with, so here is the same judgement as numbers. Six criteria, scored 1 to 5, weighted for an Indian buyer who is paying out of their own pocket. A 5 is always the favourable end: a 5 on entry cost means cheap, a 5 on holding cost means cheap to keep, a 5 on prep burden means light.

Credential	Entry cost	India relevance	Signal	Holding cost	Prep burden	Fresher fit	Total /30
Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901)	5	4	3	5	4	5	**26**
Google Generative AI Leader	3	3	3	3	5	3	**20**
AWS AI Practitioner	3	4	3	3	3	4	**20**
NVIDIA NCA-GENL	3	2	3	2	3	3	**16**
Databricks Gen AI Engineer	2	5	4	2	2	1	**16**
AWS Gen AI Developer – Pro	1	4	5	2	1	1	**14**
GCP Professional ML Engineer	2	3	4	2	1	1	**13**
GCP Professional Agentic Architect	2	4	4	1	1	1	**13**

How to read it. The two credentials tied at the top of the middle group are telling you something real: the Google business exam and the AWS foundational exam are both good, and which one wins depends entirely on whether your job is talking about AI or doing it. The Databricks exam scores 16 despite being the most useful credential on the list for the right person — its India relevance score is the highest of any credential here, because RAG demand is growing faster than anything else, but it is close to worthless to someone without platform access. That is not a contradiction; it is what buy if means.

Change the weights and the ranking changes, which is the point of showing the arithmetic. If you already have three years of production experience, drop the fresher-fit column entirely and the two Professional exams jump. If you are paying from a student budget, double the entry-cost column and AI-901 wins by a distance.

Part 4 — The Recertification Trap

Every fee table in the certification industry quotes the price of one attempt. Almost no buyer computes what the credential costs to hold. Here is that arithmetic, assuming you pass first time on every cycle and never let a credential lapse — the best case.

Credential	Fee	Validity	Attempts in 6 years	Six-year cost	Per year
Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901)	$99	Never	1	$99	$16.50
AWS AI Practitioner	$100	3 years	2	$200	$33
Google Generative AI Leader	$99	3 years	2	$198	$33
NVIDIA NCA-GENL	$125	2 years	3	$375	$62.50
Databricks Gen AI Engineer	$200	2 years	3	$600	$100
GCP Professional ML Engineer	$200	2 years	3	$600	$100
AWS Gen AI Developer – Pro	$300	3 years	2	$600	$100
GCP Professional Agentic Architect	$200	1 year	6	$1,200	$200

Three lessons fall out of that column.

A never-expiring credential is worth roughly twice its sticker price in comparison. AI-901 costs ₹3,691 and is yours permanently. The AWS AI Practitioner costs more than twice as much in rupees and then asks for another payment at year three. If your reason for getting a certificate is that it stays on your CV, the permanent one wins on both counts.

Two-year credentials are the quiet budget killer. A $200 exam with a two-year cycle is a $100-a-year subscription to a line on your CV. That is fine if the credential is load-bearing for your job — a Databricks engineer in a Databricks shop should absolutely hold it. It is not fine if you bought it once to feel qualified.

Do not pay for a one-year credential unless your employer pays. At $200 a year, the Agentic Architect is the most expensive thing on this list to hold, and it is the newest. Hold it when the job requires it, not before.

> **The question to ask before you pay**
> Not "how much is the exam?" but "what will this cost me per year for as long as I want it on my CV, and will I actually renew it?" Most people quietly stop renewing at the second cycle — which means the $600 they thought they spent bought them four years of a lapsed credential.

Part 5 — The ₹0 Route

Before you spend anything, know exactly what free gets you, because "free AI certification" is one of the most misleading phrases in this market. Three different things get called free: a shareable badge, a certificate of completion, and a training record that is not a credential at all. Here is the honest map.

Free option	What you actually receive	Time
IBM SkillsBuild — AI Foundations	Free shareable badge across AI fundamentals, generative AI and ethics. The most generous genuinely free option with a recognisable brand.	3–10 hrs
Google Skills — Introduction to Generative AI	Free badge. About 45 minutes. Google Skills replaced Google Cloud Skills Boost in 2025; many courses and skill badges are free.	~45 min
Elements of AI (University of Helsinki)	Free certificate on completion. Plain-language AI concepts, no coding, real academic credibility.	24–48 hrs
Microsoft Learn — AI fundamentals path	Free training and profile achievements. Not a credential: you pay only if you later sit AI-901.	Self-paced
AWS Skill Builder + AWS Educate	900+ free self-paced courses; completion badges on some. AWS Educate is free to join with just an email.	Self-paced
Kaggle — Intro to Machine Learning	Free certificate, plus notebooks and datasets you can show. The best free way to build visible evidence.	~3 hrs
DeepLearning.AI short courses	Free to learn (during the platform's beta); the completion record needs the paid Pro plan. No free certificate.	36 min–3 hrs each
Coursera financial aid	Per-course discount on the certificate; Coursera asks you to allow up to 16 days for a decision. Most courses let you preview the first module free.	Varies

What free genuinely does

A free badge proves initiative, which is worth more than people think. It is the cheapest possible answer to "did this person go and learn something without being told to?" — and for a career changer with no AI history, that is exactly the question an interviewer is trying to answer. It also costs nothing to test whether the subject holds your interest for thirty days, which is the single most expensive mistake in this market: buying a ₹40,000 course in a field you will abandon in week three.

What free does not do

It will not pass a filter that names a credential. If a posting says "AI-901 preferred" or a screening tool searches for a certification name, a badge from a free course will not match. Free credentials are also not assessed by an examiner, which matters precisely because 60% of employers say AI has made it harder to verify whether skills are real.

Only after that week should you decide whether to pay. If the week bored you, you have saved yourself five figures. If it did not, you now know which exam to buy — and you will pass it first time, because you have something to attach the theory to.

The exact week-one sequence

When	Do this	What you walk away with
Day 1 45 min	Google Skills — Introduction to Generative AI	A free badge and the vocabulary
Days 2–3 3 hrs	Kaggle — Intro to Machine Learning	A free certificate and a notebook you can show
Days 4–6 6 hrs	Build one small thing that uses an API key and produces output you would actually send to a person. Not a tutorial clone.	Something real to talk about
Day 7 1 hr	Write 200 words on what broke and how you fixed it	The paragraph that beats a certificate in an interview

Part 6 — The Five Traps

Trap 1: Confusing a certificate with a certificate of completion

A proctored certification is issued after an invigilated exam by a body that can verify it. A certificate of completion is issued because you finished watching. Both are called "certificates", both go on LinkedIn, and only one of them is checkable. Before you pay for anything, find the words "proctored", "exam", "passing score" and "validity" on the vendor's page. If none of them appear, you are buying a course, not a credential — which may still be fine, but price it accordingly.

Trap 2: Paying course-bundle prices for exam-priced knowledge

This is the expensive one. An Indian edtech programme can charge ₹40,000 to ₹2,00,000 for an "AI certification" that bundles recorded lectures, a capstone and a placement-assistance promise. The proctored vendor exam underneath it may cost ₹3,691. You are not being overcharged for the exam — you are paying for structure, a cohort, a deadline and, sometimes, genuine mentorship.

That can be a rational purchase. But do the comparison explicitly: **what does the bundle give me that free Microsoft Learn, free AWS Skill Builder, the official exam guide and one booked exam date do not?** If the answer is "a person who will notice if I stop", that is worth something real — especially if you have a history of not finishing things. If the answer is "a certificate with the edtech's logo on it", you are paying five figures for a logo that no recruiter screens for.

A useful rule: the moment a programme markets placement guarantees, ask what the guarantee actually commits them to in writing. Most "100% placement assistance" promises commit to sharing job links, not to employment.

Trap 3: Studying for a retired exam

Exams retire constantly, and the Indian internet is full of courses for the previous version. Concrete examples from this year alone: Microsoft retired AI-900 on 30 June 2026 and replaced it with AI-901, whose blueprint is materially different and now expects basic Python; AWS's Generative AI Developer – Professional beta pricing ($150) closed on 31 March 2026 and the exam now costs $300; NVIDIA's AI Practitioner exam in Italian and German was retired after 15 October 2026; Google's Agentic Architect beta closed on 30 September 2026.

The defence takes thirty seconds: open the official exam page, and look for the exam code, the "last updated" date, and any retirement notice. If a course you are considering names an exam code that does not match the vendor's current page, do not buy it.

Trap 4: Betting on a retake you cannot afford

Nobody plans to fail, and everybody should budget for it. Microsoft: retakes are charged, with a 24-hour wait and then 14 days between attempts, maximum five in 12 months. AWS: 14-day wait, no attempt cap, full fee each time. NVIDIA: 14-day wait, five attempts maximum in 12 months, and you purchase the exam again. Databricks: no free retakes at all, and 14 days between attempts. For an Indian buyer, one failed Databricks attempt means another ₹19,000 — which is why Part 8's plans build in a practice checkpoint before you book rather than after.

There is also a policy trap worth knowing: attempting to get around a retake policy — for example by registering under a different name or email — can lead to the certification being denied or revoked. Read the terms once.

Trap 5: Putting a badge where a portfolio should be

Recall the hiring-manager data from Part 1: certifications ranked fourth as a way to demonstrate AI skills (15%), behind describing impact (26%) and work examples (19%) — and 21% of hiring managers would rather you did not emphasise AI at all. The trap is not getting a certificate. The trap is stopping there, and letting the badge stand in for the demonstration. A certificate with nothing behind it tells an interviewer one thing: this person can pass exams.

Part 7 — What to Build Instead (and Alongside)

If you take one thing from this book, take this: thirty days of building will change your interview outcomes more than any certificate on the list, and it costs nothing. Here is the minimum viable proof, in the order that hiring managers actually read it.

The three-piece proof pack

Piece 1 — something that runs. One working thing that uses a model to do a job you personally have. A script that reads your bank SMS exports and categorises them. A tool that drafts replies to the enquiries you actually get. A retrieval assistant over your own notes. It does not need to be original, hosted, or impressive to an engineer. It needs to be real, and you need to be able to explain what it does badly.

Piece 2 — a written teardown. Six hundred words on one decision: why you chose the model you chose, what it cost per thousand calls, what failed, and what you would change. This is the artefact that separates people who have built from people who have watched. Publish it anywhere — a LinkedIn article, a GitHub README, a Notion page.

Piece 3 — a measured result. One number, honestly obtained. "Cut the time to draft a client proposal from 90 minutes to 25." "Reduced a support inbox from 60 daily messages to 40 after triage." Numbers that came from your own work, that you can defend under questioning. Never invent one: the entire value of the number is that you can explain how you got it.

How to write the certificate line on a resume

One line, in the certifications section, with the code and the year: Microsoft Certified: Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901), 2026. Not in your headline. Not as a badge row above your name. The reason is arithmetic: 15% of hiring managers value certifications, 21% are put off by AI emphasis, and 26% want to hear about impact. Put the impact in the summary and the credential in the certifications list, and you serve all three groups.

The interview answer that makes a certificate irrelevant

When asked about AI experience, the strongest structure is: what you built, what it cost, what broke, what you changed. Ninety seconds, no jargon, no tool-name dropping. A candidate who can do that does not need to mention a certificate at all — and if they do mention it, it lands as corroboration rather than as the whole claim. This is the entire argument of Part 1 compressed into one answer.

Part 8 — Three 30-Day Plans

One plan per reader. Each assumes about an hour a day on weekdays and two hours on weekends. All three end with a booked exam date, because booking early is the only accountability mechanism that has ever worked reliably.

Plan A — Non-technical professional (target: Google Cloud Generative AI Leader)

Week	Focus	Deliverable by Sunday
1	Free Google Skills: Introduction to Generative AI and Introduction to Large Language Models. Write down every term you cannot explain to a colleague.	A one-page glossary in your own words
2	The four exam domains, weighted: fundamentals (~30%), Google Cloud gen-AI offerings (~35%), improving model output (~20%), business strategy (~15%). Spend time in proportion.	A one-page map of which Google product does what
3	Apply it: draft an AI proposal for a real process in your own job — cost, risk, expected saving, who owns it. Then test every claim against what you learned.	A one-page internal proposal you could actually send
4	Two timed practice runs, then book the exam. Reserve a quiet 90 minutes, check your ID and your webcam before the day.	Exam booked

Plan B — Fresher or student (target: Microsoft AI-901)

Week	Focus	Deliverable by Sunday
1	Microsoft Learn's free AI fundamentals path plus the official practice assessment. Do not buy anything yet. Note your practice score.	Practice assessment baseline score
2	Close the gaps. Focus hardest on the bigger domain — implementing AI solutions with Microsoft Foundry, 55–60% of marks. Basic Python syntax is now assumed, so fix that first if it is shaky.	A list of every topic you got wrong, with fixes
3	Build one small Foundry-based thing and write 200 words on what it got wrong. This is the project you will talk about in interviews; the certificate is only the door-opener.	A working demo plus a short write-up
4	Two full practice runs above the pass mark, then book AI-901 at the ₹3,691 India price. Sit it online with a stable connection and a government ID.	Exam booked or passed

Plan C — Working developer (target: Databricks Gen AI Engineer, or AWS AIP-C01)

Week	Focus	Deliverable by Sunday
1	Read the official exam guide line by line and map each domain to something you have already built. The gaps you find this week are the whole study plan.	A gap list scored by domain weighting
2	Build the missing capability end to end — for Databricks that means RAG with AI Search, Model Serving, MLflow and Unity Catalog; for AWS it means Bedrock, prompt management and an agentic flow.	One working pipeline, not a notebook
3	The 30% you would skip: evaluation and monitoring, governance, cost and performance optimisation. This is where most failures live, and it is where interviewers probe.	A written evaluation of your own pipeline
4	Timed practice under exam conditions, then book. At $200–$300 with no free retake, do not book until you are consistently comfortable — an extra week is the cheapest insurance available.	Exam booked

The checkpoint before you pay

Do not book until you can pass the official practice assessment twice in a row, comfortably, under time. If the vendor offers no practice exam — Databricks does not — write your own twenty questions from the exam guide and answer them cold, a week apart. If you cannot, you are not ready, and the retake fee is larger than the week you would have spent.

Part 9 — The Budget Planner

Four honest budgets. Every one of them ends with a credential or a portfolio, and none of them requires a course bundle.

Scenario	What you buy	Total
Zero	Google Skills badge + Kaggle certificate + one self-built project + a published write-up	₹0
Starter	AI-901 at the India price, plus free Microsoft Learn prep. Never expires.	₹3,691
Working professional	AI-901 (₹3,691) or AWS AI Practitioner (₹8,553), plus a domain name and a small cloud bill for the project	₹5,000–₹12,000
Specialist	Databricks or GCP Professional at $200 (~ ₹19,000), plus budget for one retake, plus real cloud usage	₹35,000–₹40,000

Two things to notice. First, the jump from "starter" to "specialist" is ten times the money for a credential that is worth more only if you are already working in that stack. Second, in every scenario the cheapest line item is the project, and the project is the thing that actually gets you interviews.

The eight-point check before you pay

- **1. Is the exam current?** Check the exam code and the last-updated date on the vendor's own page. Confirm no retirement notice.
- **2. Is the fee the fee?** Read the line about taxes. Check whether a rupee price exists before you let a card convert dollars.
- **3. What is the validity, and what will renewal cost?** Multiply by the number of years you intend to hold it.
- **4. What is the retake policy?** Assume you might need one. Budget for it.
- **5. Does the job you want actually name it?** Search twenty real postings for your target role and count how many mention it. If none do, you are buying a personal milestone, which is fine — just know that is what it is.
- **6. Can you pass the official practice assessment twice?** If there is no practice assessment, write your own.
- **7. Will your employer reimburse it?** Many do, and asking costs one email. This is the highest-return five minutes in the whole process.
- **8. Do you have one project to attach it to?** If not, do Part 7 first. The certificate will keep.

Part 10 — Templates, Scripts and a Decision Tree

Everything in this part is copy-paste ready. It exists because the difference between having a certificate and having it work for you is usually a handful of sentences — an email to your employer, one line on a resume, and one answer in an interview.

10.1 The reimbursement email

Send this before you pay, not after. Many Indian employers will fund a vendor certification because it is cheap and it improves a team's billable credentials — but almost nobody asks. Replace the bracketed parts.

> **Subject: Request to fund one certification exam — [exam name and code], [fee]**
> Hi [manager],
>
> I would like to request approval for one certification exam: [full credential name] ([exam code]) from [vendor], at [fee, e.g. ₹3,691 for the India price / $200 plus tax].
>
> The reason it is relevant to my work is specific: [one sentence — e.g. our team is being asked to scope AI work for two clients this quarter, and this exam covers exactly the evaluation, governance and cost questions those conversations keep hitting]. The exam blueprint is here: [official URL].
>
> What I am asking for is only the exam fee. I will prepare using the vendor's free learning path and the official practice assessment, on my own time. If I fail the first attempt, I will cover the retake myself.
>
> If approved, I will book it for [date] and share the credential once issued. Happy to walk you through the syllabus first if that helps.
>
> Thanks,
> [Name]

Three things make that email work: the fee is small enough to approve without a meeting, the reason is tied to work the manager already cares about, and you have removed the risk by offering to fund a retake yourself. If the answer is no, you have lost five minutes.

10.2 Three ways to write the line on a resume

Pick one and keep it consistent. All three put the credential where a recruiter looks for it, and none of them shout.

- **Certifications section (default):** Microsoft Certified: Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901) — Microsoft, 2026.
- **With a result attached (best if you built something):** Microsoft Certified: Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901), 2026 — used it to ship an internal document-Q&A; tool that cut policy lookups from 20 minutes to under 2.
- **For a career switch:** Microsoft Certified: Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901), 2026 — taken while moving from [previous field] into AI-supported operations; project work at [link].

Never put it in your headline. About one in five hiring managers says AI emphasis puts them off, and only 15% rank certifications as their preferred proof of AI skill. The headline is for what you do; the certifications section is for what you have been examined on.

10.3 The LinkedIn entry, done properly

Use the Licenses & certifications section, not a badge row above your name. Fill all four fields — name, issuing organisation, issue date and the credential URL — because the URL is what makes it checkable, and checkability is the entire point of a proctored credential.

Example entry

Name: Microsoft Certified: Azure AI Fundamentals
Issuing organisation: Microsoft
Issue date: [month, year] · Expiration: does not expire
Credential ID / URL: [the verification link from your certification dashboard]

For a credential that does expire, put the expiry in the entry. A recruiter who finds a lapsed credential with no expiry date assumes the worst.

10.4 The ninety-second interview answer

This is the answer that makes the certificate irrelevant, and it is the one most candidates never prepare. Four beats: what you built, what it cost, what broke, what you changed.

Skeleton, filled for an operations analyst

What I built: "We were getting about 60 supplier emails a day and everything was being sorted by hand. I built a small tool that reads each email and tags it — quote, invoice, complaint, or spam — and drafts a reply for the first two."

What it cost: "Under ₹2,000 a month in API calls at our volume, and about three weekends to build."

What broke: "Anything with a scanned attachment in Hindi failed completely, and it confidently mislabelled one credit note as a quote. That was the useful failure — it taught me to route low-confidence items to a person rather than to keep tuning the prompt."

What I changed: "So now every item under a confidence threshold goes to a queue a human clears, and we measure the queue length rather than the accuracy percentage. Mis-sorts fell to about two a day."

Then stop. If they want the certificate, they will ask — and now it lands as corroboration, not as the claim.

10.5 The decision tree

Ask yourself, in this order	If yes	If no
Have I built anything with a model that I could show someone?	Go to the next question.	Stop. Do Part 7 first. It costs ₹0 and matters more.

Ask yourself, in this order	If yes	If no
Does the job I want name a specific certification?	Buy that exam. Nothing else on this list matters.	Next question.
Does my employer use Azure, AWS, Google Cloud or Databricks?	Buy the foundational exam for that platform.	Next question.
Am I non-technical and need to talk credibly about AI?	Google Cloud Generative AI Leader.	Next question.
Am I a fresher with under ₹5,000 to spend?	Microsoft AI-901 at the India price. Never expires.	Next question.
Do I have 2+ years of production experience in a specific stack?	The Professional-level exam for that stack — and only if the employer will part-fund it.	Take the foundational exam, build for six months, then reassess.

10.6 The six months after you pass

When	Do this	Why
Day 1	Download the score report and credential URL. Add the entry to LinkedIn and to your CV in the certifications section, with the code and year.	The credential's only value is that it is findable and checkable.
Week 1	Publish the 600-word teardown of the project you built. Link it from your profile.	This converts a credential into evidence, which is what the research says actually moves interviews.
Month 2	Put the credential's date in your calendar with a reminder 60 days before expiry — Google opens recertification 60 days early.	A lapsed credential looks worse than no credential, because it suggests you did not notice.
Month 3	Teach it once: a 20-minute internal session, a LinkedIn post, or a short write-up for your team.	Explaining it is the cheapest way to find out whether you actually understood it.
Month 6	Re-run the six-point verification in the Appendix against the exam you hold. Blueprints change every year.	This is how you avoid becoming the person who studied for a retired exam.

Part 11 — The Practice Sampler

Eight questions, written in the style of the published blueprints, to show you what these exams actually feel like. **These are original questions written for this book. They are not official exam items, they are not drawn from any live exam, and no vendor has reviewed or endorsed them.** Use them to calibrate your studying, not to predict your score.

Foundational level (AI-901, AI Practitioner, Generative AI Leader)

Q1. A team wants an assistant that answers questions from 400 internal policy PDFs and shows the exact passage it used. Which approach fits best?

A. Fine-tune a model on the PDFs. B. Retrieve relevant passages at query time and pass them to the model with the question. C. Increase the model's temperature. D. Put all 400 PDFs in the system prompt.

Answer: B. Retrieval at query time grounds the answer in current documents and gives you a passage to cite. Fine-tuning teaches style and behaviour, not fresh facts; a high temperature increases randomness; and stuffing 400 PDFs into a prompt is neither affordable nor reliable. Expect variations of this question on every generative-AI exam on this list.

Q2. Your assistant answers correctly 90% of the time but is confidently wrong on the rest, and users cannot tell which is which. What is the most appropriate fix?

A. Switch to a larger model. B. Return a confidence signal and route low-confidence answers to a human. C. Add more few-shot examples to the prompt. D. Restrict the assistant to a shorter answer length.

Answer: B. The problem is not accuracy, it is undetectable failure. Design that surfaces uncertainty and routes it to a person is the answer these exams reward, and it is also the answer that survives a real deployment. This is the same judgement the AI-901 blueprint tests under responsible AI and the Generative AI Leader blueprint tests under improving model output.

Q3. A retail chain wants to cut customer-support costs with generative AI. Which is the most defensible first step?

A. Replace the support team with a chatbot. B. Pilot on one high-volume, low-risk query type, with a measured baseline and human escalation. C. Fine-tune a model on the last five years of tickets. D. Buy the largest model available.

Answer: B. The business-strategy domain of the Generative AI Leader exam (about 15% of the paper) rewards pilots with a baseline, a defined scope and an escalation path. Options A and D are the two failure modes the exam is written to filter out.

Q4. On AWS, which capability lets you adapt a foundation model to your own labelled examples rather than supplying context at query time?

A. Retrieval-augmented generation. B. Fine-tuning. C. Prompt caching. D. Guardrails.

Answer: B. Fine-tuning changes the model's weights using your examples. RAG supplies context at query time, caching reduces cost and latency, and guardrails filter inputs and outputs. The AI Practitioner exam expects you to place each of these correctly.

Associate and Professional level

Q5. A RAG application answers well in testing but returns irrelevant passages in production. Which component do you investigate first on Databricks?

A. Model Serving configuration. B. The semantic retrieval layer and its index freshness. C. MLflow experiment naming. D. Unity Catalog permissions.

Answer: B. Irrelevant passages point at retrieval, not generation — chunking, embedding choice, index staleness or filter logic. Databricks weights assembling and deploying at 22% and application development at 30%, and retrieval failures are the most common real-world cause of the symptom described.

Q6. You need to prove, six months after deployment, which model version and prompt produced a specific answer. Which capability matters most?

A. A larger context window. B. Lifecycle tracking that records the model version, prompt and parameters per request. C. A cheaper inference tier. D. A second model to review the first.

Answer: B. This is traceability, and it sits in the evaluation-and-monitoring and governance domains. On Databricks that means MLflow plus Unity Catalog; on Google Cloud it means the MLOps and governance domains of the Professional ML Engineer exam.

Q7. A model performs well offline but poorly once deployed, because features are computed differently in the pipeline than in training. What is this called, and what fixes it?

A. Overfitting; add regularisation. B. Training-serving skew; use a shared feature pipeline. C. Data drift; retrain weekly. D. Class imbalance; resample the data.

Answer: B. Training-serving skew is the classic production failure in the Professional ML Engineer blueprint, and the fix is a single feature definition used by both paths. Drift is a different problem — the world changed, not your pipeline.

Q8. A developer's agentic workflow completes tasks but occasionally takes an irreversible action it should not. Which control belongs in the design?

A. A longer system prompt asking it to be careful. B. An explicit approval gate for irreversible actions, with the allowed tool set restricted by policy. C. A second agent that reviews afterwards. D. Lowering the temperature to zero.

Answer: B. Guardrails that constrain what a tool can do beat instructions that ask a model to behave. The Agentic Architect blueprint devotes about 15% to securing and governing agentic workflows, and the AWS Professional exam tests the same instinct under responsible-AI practice.

How to use this sampler honestly

If you got six or more right without looking anything up, you are probably ready for a foundational exam and close for an Associate. If you got four or fewer, do not book yet — the retake fee is always larger than the study week you would have spent. And note the pattern in every answer: the right option is the one that adds a control, a measurement or a human in the loop. Exams in this field are mostly testing whether you think like an engineer, not whether you memorised a product list.

Part 12 — Exam Day, Without Disasters

Every credential here is proctored, and the failure modes are administrative rather than technical. Here is the checklist that prevents the avoidable ones.

Before you book

- **Register with a personal account, not a work or college one.** Microsoft states this explicitly: if you register with an organisational account and later leave that organisation, your exam records are lost and cannot be recovered. The same logic applies to any vendor account tied to an employer's domain.
- **Check your name.** The name on your booking must match your government photo ID exactly. A mismatch is the single most common reason people are turned away from a proctored exam.
- **Book the slot you will actually keep.** AWS permits only two reschedules on a certification exam. Other vendors publish their own windows — NVIDIA allows cancellation or rescheduling up to 24 hours before the appointment, and Databricks reschedules are free only if made far enough ahead. Read the confirmation email before you assume you can move it.

The day before

- Run the vendor's system test on the same machine and network you will use. Do it at the same time of day as your slot if you can.
- Have your government photo ID on the desk, and nothing else. Proctors ask for a room scan, and a second monitor, a phone or a notebook within reach is grounds for ending the session.
- Close everything else. Not minimised — closed. Background applications that pop notifications get flagged.
- Tell the people you live with. A door opening mid-exam is the most common interruption.

During the exam

- Read the question stem twice on scenario questions. These exams are written so that two options are technically true and one is right for the stated constraints.
- Answer everything. There is no penalty for a wrong answer on any of these exams, so never leave a blank.
- Flag and move on. On a 90-minute, 65-question paper you have roughly 80 seconds a question; a question you cannot answer in three minutes is a question to come back to.
- Watch the clock at the halfway mark, not the end.

Afterwards

You get an unofficial result immediately on most of these exams, with the formal credential following after proctor review. Save the score report. Add the credential to LinkedIn and your CV the same day, while the project you built to prepare is still fresh — that is when the write-up is easiest to produce, and the write-up is the part that actually gets read.

If you fail: wait out the mandated period rather than rebooking in frustration — 24 hours then 14 days for Microsoft, 14 days for AWS, NVIDIA and Databricks — and spend that time on the domain where your score report says you were weakest. Do not buy a second attempt until you can pass a practice run comfortably. The retake is always the most expensive way to learn something you could have learned for free.

Part 13 — Questions People Actually Ask

Will an AI certificate get me a job?

No — but it will get you read. In the 2026 recruiter experiment, AI skills lifted interview invitations by 8 to 15 percentage points, while formal certificates added only a modest amount on top of simply declaring the skill. The certificate's job is to make an unverifiable claim verifiable. Getting hired still requires a project and an interview.

Which is the best value AI certificate in India right now?

Microsoft Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901), on three counts: it is the cheapest at a published ₹3,691 India price, it never expires so there is no renewal arithmetic, and it is proctored and checkable. It is a foundational credential, so it will not impress a senior engineering manager — but for a first AI credential it is the best rupee-per-signal on the market.

Is a ₹50,000 edtech AI course worth it?

Only if what you are buying is structure, a cohort and a deadline — and only if you know you will not finish without them. The proctored exam underneath such a programme often costs under ₹4,000. Compare the bundle against free official learning paths plus one booked exam date, and be specific about what extra you are paying for.

Are free AI certificates worth anything?

Yes, as evidence of initiative and as a low-cost way to test whether the subject interests you. No, as a substitute for a proctored credential: free badges are not examined, and they will not match a screening filter that names a specific exam. Start free, then pay once, deliberately.

Do I need to know Python?

For AI-901, Microsoft now expects basic Python syntax and familiarity with Azure resources — the 2026 version is materially harder than its predecessor. For the Generative AI Leader exam, no. For the Databricks, GCP Professional and AWS Professional exams, yes, plus real hands-on experience.

How long should I study?

Two to four weeks for a foundational exam with an hour a day, six to twelve weeks for a Professional-level one. The plans in Part 8 are a reasonable default. What matters more than total hours is whether you have built something with the tools the exam asks about.

Can I take these exams from home in India?

Yes. Every credential on this list offers online proctoring, and Microsoft, AWS and Google also offer test centres. Requirements are a stable connection, a working webcam and microphone, a quiet room and a government photo ID. NVIDIA's exams are delivered online through Certiverse with no test-centre option.

What if I fail?

You pay again. Microsoft charges for retakes with a 24-hour wait and then 14 days between attempts, capped at five in 12 months; AWS waits 14 days with no cap; NVIDIA waits 14 days with a five-attempt cap in 12 months; Databricks has no free retakes and a 14-day wait. This is the strongest argument for booking only when you are ready, and for budgeting one retake.

Does a certificate expire?

Most do. Three years for AWS AI Practitioner, the AWS Professional exam and Google's Generative AI Leader; two years for NVIDIA, Databricks and Google's Professional ML Engineer; one year for Google's new Agentic Architect. Microsoft Fundamentals certifications never expire — the only permanent one here.

Should I put it on LinkedIn?

Yes, in the Licenses and Certifications section, with the exam code and year. Not in your headline, and not as a badge row above your name: about one in five hiring managers says AI emphasis puts them off, and only 15% rank certifications as their preferred proof. The impact story belongs in your summary; the credential belongs in its own section.

What about AI certificates from Indian universities and institutes?

They can be excellent, and some carry more local weight than a vendor credential — particularly for campus placements and for government or public-sector roles where institutional names matter. Treat them as a separate category with the same test: is the assessment proctored, what is the fee per year of validity, and does the job you want name it? A university certificate is usually a course completion, not a licensure.

Is the new Google Agentic Architect worth waiting for?

The exam design is the best on this list — a written paper plus hands-on labs, which tests ability rather than recall. But GA had not opened at the time of writing (registration was scheduled to open 2 November 2026), and the validity is one year, which makes it $200 a year to hold. Prepare now, book when the GA format is published.

Appendix — Sources and How to Re-Verify

Every factual claim about fees, formats and validity in this book comes from the pages below, read on 28 October 2026. Vendors change these pages without notice, so treat the list as a starting point, not a citation you can rely on next year.

Official exam pages

- Microsoft Azure AI Fundamentals (AI-901) — learn.microsoft.com/credentials/certifications/azure-ai-fundamentals/
- Microsoft exam AI-901 — learn.microsoft.com/credentials/certifications/exams/ai-901/
- AWS Certified AI Practitioner — aws.amazon.com/certification/certified-ai-practitioner/
- AWS exam pricing, including rupee pricing on the Pearson Mindhub voucher store — aws.amazon.com/certification/policies/before-testing/
- AWS Certified Generative AI Developer – Professional — aws.amazon.com/certification/certified-generative-ai-developer-professional/
- Google Cloud Generative AI Leader — cloud.google.com/learn/certification/generative-ai-leader
- Google Cloud Professional Machine Learning Engineer — cloud.google.com/learn/certification/machine-learning-engineer
- Google Cloud Professional Agentic Architect — cloud.google.com/learn/certification/agentic-architect
- NVIDIA NCA-GENL — nvidia.com/en-us/learn/certification/generative-ai-llm-associate/
- Databricks Certified Generative AI Engineer Associate — databricks.com/learn/certification/genai-engineer-associate
- Databricks certification FAQ — databricks.com/learn/certification/faq
- Google Skills (formerly Google Cloud Skills Boost) — skills.google
- AWS Skill Builder and AWS Educate — aws.amazon.com/training/

Research cited in Part 1

- Recruiter conjoint experiment, 1,725 recruiters in the UK, US and Germany, on the labour-market value of AI skills and AI credentials (2026 working paper).
- WGU Workforce Decoded Annual Report 2026 — 3,128 employers; certificate value, and the AI skills-verification gap.
- Pearson VUE, 2026 Value of IT Certification Employer Report — 500+ IT and HR leaders across seven countries.
- Resume Genius survey of hiring managers, as reported in 2026, on how candidates should demonstrate AI skills.
- Study.com career readiness survey, 2026, on AI literacy as a hiring criterion.

The six-point re-verification routine

Run this before you pay, every time. It takes four minutes and it has saved people more money than any discount code.

- **1.** Open the vendor's exam page from the links above. Confirm the exam code is the one you are studying for.
- **2.** Find the "last updated" or "exam guide updated" date. If it is newer than your study material, re-read the blueprint.

- **3.** Check for a retirement notice anywhere on the page.
- **4.** Confirm the fee, and whether a rupee price is published for India.
- **5.** Confirm the validity period and the retake policy in writing.
- **6.** Ask your employer about reimbursement before you pay, not after.

A note on the numbers

Rupee figures marked ~ are conversions at ₹95 = $1, the market rate on 27 October 2026. They exclude tax, exclude any currency-markup fee your card issuer charges, and exclude preparation costs. Where a vendor publishes its own India price — Microsoft's ₹3,691 for Fundamentals and AWS's ₹8,553 for its Foundational tier — that published figure is used instead, because it is the number you will actually be asked to pay.

One last thing

The certificate is the cheapest part of getting good at this. The expensive part is the year you spend waiting to feel ready. Buy the ₹3,691 exam, build the small thing, and publish the paragraph about what broke. That combination beats any credential on this list, including the ones that cost eight times as much.